

What else to watch: *Little Caesar* (1931) ■ *The Public Enemy* (1931) ■ *Scarface* (1932, p.339) ■ *White Heat* (1949) ■ *The Long Good Friday* (1980) ■ *Rumble Fish* (1983) ■ *Once Upon a Time in America* (1984) ■ *Goodfellas* (1990)

The Corleones want to appear as a respectable American family. The marriage of Don Corleone's daughter, Connie, is a lavish affair, but the invited senators and judges stay away.

to establish their place in the world. Few movies have focused quite so starkly on the moral contradictions involved in this pursuit.

Justice and loyalty

The movie opens with the wedding celebration of Don Corleone's daughter, Connie (Talia Shire), at which the undertaker Bonasera, a family associate, seeks a private audience with Don Corleone. Bonasera asks the Godfather's help in avenging the beating and rape of his daughter by men who escaped justice through being wealthy and well connected. "I believe in America," Bonasera says. "America has made my fortune. And I raised my daughter in the American fashion." He has bought into the American Dream, yet America has betrayed him. To Don Corleone, then, falls the task of getting justice for Bonasera and his



daughter outside of the law. It is no accident that the movie begins at a family gathering. The Corleones are presented as a family that must remain close-knit in order to survive in the world. Loyalty is everything. Later in the movie, Michael warns his brother Fredo, "Don't ever take sides with anyone against the family again. Ever." Domestic

exchanges such as this are central to this portrayal of the Corleone family. There are, in fact, many more scenes set around the dinner table than there are shoot-outs. The men describe what they do as business, which they keep strictly separate from family. "This is business, not personal," they insist. They see themselves simply as men doing their job. »



Marlon Brando Actor

A Hollywood actor renowned for his brooding presence and the championing of the "Method" style of acting, Marlon Brando was born in 1924 in Omaha, Nebraska. After being expelled from military school, he enrolled in Lee Strasberg's Actors Studio in New York, where he was coached by Stella Adler. In 1947, he was a sensation in Tennessee Williams' play *A Streetcar Named Desire*. Four years later, he reprised his role in the movie. He received his

first Academy Award for playing a longshoreman in Elia Kazan's *On the Waterfront*. In the 1960s, Brando's career hit a low, but was revived in 1972 with *The Godfather* and *Last Tango in Paris*. He died in 2004.

Key movies

1951 *A Streetcar Named Desire*
1954 *On the Waterfront*
1972 *The Godfather*
1972 *Last Tango in Paris*